

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Bookkeeping and Payroll English



Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Bookkeepers, accounts payable and receivable clerks, payroll clerks, and accounting assistants.

All organizations, records, amounts, deadlines, and incidents are fictional English-language practice. This course is not accounting, payroll-system, tax, employment-law, financial, or payment-processing advice. Internal deadlines in the exercises are not legal rules. Refer pay entitlements, deductions, posting treatments, corrections, and payment decisions to the responsible qualified people and applicable local requirements. Use invented employee and account details only.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

accounts receivable

Amounts owed to an organization by customers for billed goods or services.

adjusting entry

An accounting entry made to correct or update recorded balances, subject to the applicable review.

aging report

A report grouping unpaid balances by their age or time past due, using a stated date basis.

approval cutoff

An organization's stated internal deadline for receiving approvals for a particular processing cycle.

approval matrix

An organization's guide assigning approval authority by transaction type, amount, or other criteria.

audit trail

A traceable history linking a transaction to its source, changes, and review records.

bank reconciliation

A comparison explaining differences between bank records and the organization's corresponding cash records.

close checklist

A list tracking required checks and review tasks at the end of an accounting period.

credit note

A seller's document reducing an amount previously billed, with a reference to the relevant charge.

deduction

An amount subtracted from gross pay, recorded under a specified reason or category.

delegated approver

A person given specified approval responsibility by someone with the authority to delegate it.

deposit in transit

A deposit recorded internally but not yet reflected in the bank records at the reconciliation date.

duplicate entry

A second recording of the same transaction where only one recording was intended.

gross pay

An employee's earnings amount before deductions for the specified payroll period.

invoice

A supplier's or seller's bill listing goods or services and the amount requested.

missing punch

An absent clock-in or clock-out entry in an employee's time record.

net pay

The amount remaining after deductions are subtracted from gross pay.

outstanding payment

A payment recorded internally that has not yet appeared as cleared in the bank activity being reviewed.

pay period

The defined span of work time covered by a payroll calculation.

payment batch

A group of payment instructions assembled for review or processing together.

payroll register

A payroll report listing employee earnings, deductions, and payment amounts for a processing run.

posting period

The accounting period to which an entry is assigned in the ledger.

purchase order

A buyer's purchasing document specifying the goods or services ordered.

receiving record

A record of the goods or quantities actually received by an organization.

reconciling item

An identified difference between records that must be explained, cleared, or corrected during reconciliation.

remittance advice

Information from a payer identifying the invoices or charges a payment is intended to cover.

reversal

An entry that offsets an earlier accounting entry, rather than merely deleting its visible record.

supporting document

A record supplying evidence for a transaction, its amount, purpose, receipt, or approval.

time exception

A timekeeping record flagged because information is missing, inconsistent, or requires review.

trial balance

A listing of ledger account balances used to compare total debits and credits at a stated point.

unapplied cash

A recorded receipt that has not yet been allocated to a specific customer balance or invoice.

version history

A record of successive document or data versions and their changes.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Locate the exact mismatch

The invoice shows ___, whereas the receiving record shows ___.

Could you confirm whether ___ arrived separately?

Which reference supports the remaining ___?

Name the invoice, order, and receiving record separately. Agreement between two documents does not settle a third document's different quantity. Ask about the missing evidence without assuming either a supplier error or an unrecorded delivery.

Word combinations in this lesson

match an invoice to an order: compare the supplier's bill with the purchasing reference

query a quantity difference: ask why billed and received quantities differ

link a credit note: connect a reduction to the original invoice

confirm receipt of goods: establish what arrived, not what was merely ordered

Separate receipt from allocation

We have received ___, but it has not been allocated to ___.

The open invoices total ___; the separate receipt is ___.

Which invoice does your remittance identify?

A receipt records money received. Allocation connects it to a particular balance. Do not equate an unallocated receipt with nonpayment, or assume the customer's intended allocation from the amount alone.

Word combinations in this lesson

allocate a receipt: link received money to the relevant invoice

identify the payer: establish who sent a payment

request remittance details: ask which invoices a payment covers

review an aging balance: examine an amount grouped by how long it has remained unpaid

State what one match establishes

This entry is consistent with ___ because ___.

We have traced ___; we have not completed ___.

The evidence supports ___ for this item only.

Separate the evidence for an individual item from the conclusion about the whole account. 'Consistent with' allows a supported explanation without claiming that every other entry has been checked.

Word combinations in this lesson

align the statement dates: compare records through the same day

trace a statement entry: find the related internal transaction

carry an open reconciling item: retain an unexplained difference for follow-up

clear an outstanding payment: confirm that a recorded payment appears in bank activity

Ask for the missing time fact

Could you confirm the actual ___ against ___?

The roster shows ___, while the employee recalls ___.

Please return either the confirmed detail or the open issue by ___.

Describe the absent entry and the conflicting information. An internal cutoff is a workflow deadline, not a statement about legal pay obligations. Ask the responsible reviewer for evidence and a status if the question cannot be resolved.

Word combinations in this lesson

resolve a missing punch: confirm an absent clock entry with supporting information

confirm actual hours: distinguish time worked from the planned roster

flag a time exception: identify a record needing review

meet the approval cutoff: provide a decision by the employer's stated internal deadline

Compare like-for-like payroll figures

Gross pay is unchanged, whereas ___ differs by ___.

The arithmetic difference comes from ___; the support is ___.

Are both previews for the same ___?

Keep the employee and pay period constant. Name gross pay, deductions, and net pay instead of using 'pay' for all three. A figure that adds up may still need supporting documentation.

Word combinations in this lesson

compare payroll previews: check two versions before final processing

trace a deduction line: locate the record supporting an amount withheld

reconcile the headcount: explain a difference in the number of employees listed

identify a one-time payment: distinguish a single payment from a recurring amount

Report approved, proposed, and released separately

___ items have approval; ___ remains excluded.

The batch is proposed, not yet ___.

The next review can address ___ when ___.

Approval of an invoice, approval of a batch, and release of payment may be separate events. Use the fictional organization's stated stages, and avoid saying 'paid' merely because review is complete.

Word combinations in this lesson

submit a batch for review: send a grouped set of proposed payments to the reviewer

confirm approval authority: check who may approve the specific item

exclude a disputed item: keep it outside the proposed batch while it is reviewed

retain the supporting reference: preserve the link to evidence behind a payment

Transfer the unresolved accounting question

The completed checks are ___; the remaining question is ___.

The invoice date is ___, but the service description says ___.

Please confirm you are taking over ___.

Invoice date, service period, and posting period can differ. Preserve them separately and name the person who will obtain the accountant's decision. A balanced trial balance does not answer every period question.

Word combinations in this lesson

complete a close checklist: finish and record the specified closing checks

confirm the posting period: establish the accounting period assigned to an entry

submit an adjustment for review: present a proposed correction to the reviewer

tie a schedule to the ledger: compare a supporting total with the recorded account balance

Correct the claim, not just the number

I incorrectly described ___ as ___.

The confirmed finding is ___; we have not established ___.

The correction refers back to ___ and is currently ___.

State exactly what the earlier message got wrong. A duplicate document, entry, and payment are different findings. Refer to the original record and correction status without teaching a universal reversal method.

Word combinations in this lesson

trace the original entry: locate the transaction being corrected

cross-reference a correction: link the new record to the earlier one

identify the current version: distinguish the active record from superseded copies

explain the correction reason: state what changed and why

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Matching an invoice to its supporting records

Fictional supplier Alder bills twelve desk lamps on invoice A184. Purchase order P61 lists twelve, but receiving record R9 lists ten. The remaining two may be on another delivery; no second record is available.

Invoice A184 and purchase order P61 both show twelve lamps, while receiving record R9 shows ten. Could you confirm whether the other two arrived separately or remain outstanding? I need the related delivery reference before I can describe the invoice as fully matched. At present, the two-lamp difference is unresolved.

Try it again: The supplier sends the purchase order again. Explain why it confirms the order quantity but not receipt.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Explaining receipts and outstanding customer balances

Fictional customer Pine has invoices 410 for \$600 and 411 for \$400. A \$600 receipt is identified as Pine's but has no invoice reference. Both invoices remain open in the ledger pending allocation.

We have received Pine's six hundred dollars, but the invoice allocation is still unconfirmed. The open invoices total one thousand dollars; the unapplied receipt must be shown alongside them. A remittance advice identifies what the customer intended to pay. Could you confirm the invoice reference so we can explain the remaining balance accurately?

Try it again: The amount equals invoice 410. Explain why that is a useful clue, not confirmation of the intended allocation.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Qualifying a bank reconciliation difference

In a fictional reconciliation through June 30, the bank balance is \$300 lower than the cash ledger. A \$300 deposit recorded June 30 appears on the bank's July 1 activity. Other reconciliation checks are not complete.

The three-hundred-dollar deposit recorded on June thirty appears in the bank's July first activity. That supports a timing explanation for this item. It does not establish that the whole reconciliation is complete, because the other checks are still open. I would label this deposit as traced and keep the overall review pending.

Try it again: A colleague says equal balances prove every entry is right. Distinguish agreeing totals from checking the underlying items.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Requesting evidence for time exceptions

Fictional employee Eli's Tuesday timecard lacks a clock-out entry. The roster says 17:00, but Eli recalls 17:30. The supervisor can review a work log before the internal approval cutoff at 14:00 today. Actual finish time is unconfirmed.

Could you review Eli's Tuesday finish time against the work log and confirm the supported correction before our internal two o'clock approval cutoff? The roster shows five, while Eli recalls five thirty. Neither should be presented as verified yet. If the evidence is still incomplete, please return the exception with that uncertainty clearly stated.

Try it again: The reviewer finds only the planned roster. Keep the actual finish time unresolved and identify the next evidence holder.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Explaining a payroll preview

Fictional preview A shows Morgan's gross pay of \$1,200, deductions of \$200, and net pay of \$1,000. Preview B shows the same gross pay, deductions of \$250, and net pay of \$950. A new \$50 deduction line is present; its supporting record is pending.

Both previews show gross pay of twelve hundred dollars. Preview B has fifty dollars more in deductions, so the displayed net pay is fifty dollars lower. The new line explains the arithmetic difference, but its supporting record is still pending. Could you check that line before we describe preview B as ready for final approval?

Try it again: Someone calls the extra fifty dollars a tax change. Explain that the line's reason is unconfirmed and requires the responsible specialist's review.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Making approval status unambiguous

A fictional payment batch contains eight invoices. Seven have recorded approval; invoice V22 awaits a receiving document and is excluded from the proposed seven-item batch. The batch itself has not been released. The approver returns at 15:00.

Seven invoices have recorded approval and are included in the proposed batch. V22 is excluded because its receiving document is still missing. The batch has not been released. The approver returns at three, when I can present the seven-item proposal and report separately on the missing document without calling the payments completed.

Try it again: A substitute colleague offers to approve the batch. Ask whether the recorded delegation covers this batch, without assuming seniority equals authority.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Handing over a period-close review

Fictional June close has nine of ten checklist items complete. A \$240 maintenance invoice dated July 2 describes June service. Its posting period needs the accountant's review; no adjusting entry has been approved. Alex takes over the open-item follow-up at noon.

Nine of the ten June close checks are complete. The open item is the two-hundred-forty-dollar maintenance invoice dated July second for June service. Its posting period needs the accountant's review, and no adjustment is approved. Alex, please confirm that you are taking over that follow-up and will keep the close status pending until the review outcome is recorded.

Try it again: The accountant is unavailable until tomorrow. State the owner and pending question without assigning an invented posting period.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Correcting records while preserving the trail

In fictional tracker version 3, invoice J14 for \$180 appears twice because the same file was imported twice. The controller confirmed one duplicate. No ledger correction has been posted. A previous message wrongly said the duplicate payment had been recovered; no duplicate payment is established.

My earlier message confused a duplicate entry with a duplicate payment. The controller has confirmed a repeated one-hundred-eighty-dollar invoice entry in tracker version three; we have not established that money was paid twice. No ledger correction has been posted. I am correcting the status now and linking the original entry for the controller's review of the required correction.

Try it again: A colleague proposes calling the issue fully fixed after updating the tracker. Distinguish the tracker correction from the still-pending ledger review.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

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Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics: Bookkeeping, Accounting, and Auditing Clerks

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/office-and-administrative-support/bookkeeping-accounting-and-auditing-clerks.htm>

U.S. Department of Labor: Fact Sheet 21, Recordkeeping Requirements

<https://www.dol.gov/agencies/whd/fact-sheets/21-flsa-recordkeeping>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Guided message practice gives four choices with explained feedback. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

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Lesson 01: Matching an invoice to its supporting records

Original fictional case: Fictional supplier Alder bills twelve desk lamps on invoice A184. Purchase order P61 lists twelve, but receiving record R9 lists ten. The remaining two may be on another delivery; no second record is available.

Language workshop: Locate the exact mismatch

Communication goal: Clarify which document supports a billed quantity.

Language guidance: Name the invoice, order, and receiving record separately. Agreement between two documents does not settle a third document's different quantity. Ask about the missing evidence without assuming either a supplier error or an unrecorded delivery.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): The invoice shows ___, whereas the receiving record shows ___. / Could you confirm whether ___ arrived separately? / Which reference supports the remaining ___?

Vocabulary: invoice: A supplier's or seller's bill listing goods or services and the amount requested. /

purchase order: A buyer's purchasing document specifying the goods or services ordered. / receiving

record: A record of the goods or quantities actually received by an organization. / credit note: A seller's

document reducing an amount previously billed, with a reference to the relevant charge.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Buyer: you ordered twelve lamps and can see only R9. The warehouse can check whether a second delivery occurred.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: The supplier sends the purchase order again. Explain why it confirms the order quantity but not receipt.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Invoice A184 and purchase order P61 both show twelve lamps, while receiving record R9 shows ten. Could you confirm whether the other two arrived separately or remain outstanding? I need the related delivery reference before I can describe the invoice as fully matched. At present, the two-lamp difference is unresolved.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Retrieve occupational vocabulary

1. Select four terms from the reference. Explain each in plain English, give two natural collocations and quote or create a short workplace example. Label invented examples. Contrast each term with a plausible confusable term; acknowledge regional variation.
2. Present one role-labelled exchange with one missing word or phrase and four choices A-D. Exactly one choice must fit the stated facts and grammar. Stop and wait for my answer before revealing it.
3. Explain all four options, then invite me to read the completed exchange aloud. Offer a sentence frame for optional spoken practice, never an open-ended writing assignment.
4. Repeat for the other three terms, one question at a time. Vary the correct letter and the situation; preserve the reference facts. If a choice is ambiguous, replace the item.
5. Finish with two new four-choice collocation questions for later review, with a clearly separate answer key. Do not claim to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Test recall and transfer

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Review with supported choices and speaking

1. Ask me to close my notes. Prepare six four-choice questions: two vocabulary gaps, one grammar contrast, one confirmed-versus-unknown distinction, one choice of reply, and one transfer to a clearly labelled fictional variation.
2. Show only the first question. Use a short role-labelled exchange or a concrete scenario, four plausible choices A-D, and exactly one defensible answer. Stop and wait.
3. After each answer explain all options, offer one hint for a retry if needed, and invite me to say the completed exchange aloud. Only then move on. Do not request an original written response.
4. Track whether I answered independently or with a hint, not a certified proficiency score. Do not assess pronunciation from typed text. Replace ambiguous questions and accept valid spoken alternatives.
5. Give a compact review card with three four-choice recall items and a separate answer section. Summarize two specific successes and two points to revisit. Do not claim to remember or schedule future sessions.

END PROMPT